

Those potholes in your street reveal a money problem for cities and states

BY AMANDA WATFORD - MAY 25, 2026 7:00 AM



□ A work crew fills potholes on Perring Parkway in Baltimore. Crews filled at least 32,000 potholes from late February through mid-March, and the city aims to fill another 25,000 potholes by mid-July. (Photo by J.J. McQueen/Baltimore City Mayor's Office)

Across the country, potholes are more than a seasonal nuisance. They are a visible symptom of aging roads and bridges that many state and local governments say they cannot afford to fully maintain.

From local streets in small towns to major urban corridors, transportation agencies are grappling with deferred maintenance, rising construction costs and limited revenue streams. Even as federal infrastructure dollars increased in recent years, some transportation officials and infrastructure experts say the need continues to outpace available funding.

Gas taxes, which historically have largely gone to road repairs, have not kept up with inflation or shifts in vehicle efficiency, including the growing use of fuel-efficient and electric vehicles. The federal gas tax, at 18.4 cents per gallon, has remained unchanged since 1993. President Donald Trump has proposed temporarily suspending the federal gas tax to provide relief from surging fuel prices because of the Iran war.

“What states end up doing, partly because resources are limited, is they’re sort of triaging the system,” said Rocky Moretti, the director of policy and research at TRIP, a nonprofit research group focused on transportation issues.

For drivers, the cost of deteriorating roads often becomes clear only after damage occurs. At a time when many Americans are already feeling squeezed by fluctuating gas prices, tire blowouts, bent rims and suspension repairs can turn potholes into costly and unexpected expenses.

At the same time, some state and local governments are struggling to keep up with repairs while exploring new technologies — including artificial intelligence-powered road monitoring systems, sensors and camera-equipped vehicles — to identify road damage and respond more efficiently.

Federal transportation [data](#) shows that U.S. road conditions have changed little over the past three decades. Nationwide, the share of roadways rated in acceptable condition peaked at about 91% in 1999, but has since declined and averaged around 80% in recent years — leaving roughly 1 in 5 roadways in poor condition.

In 2024, the latest year with available data, the share of road miles rated in poor condition ranged from 34% to 89% in the five states or jurisdictions with the worst roads: the District of Columbia, Rhode Island, Hawaii, California and New Mexico. By comparison, the share of roads rated in acceptable condition ranged from 94% to 97% in the five best-performing states: Kansas, Tennessee, Indiana, Wyoming and Vermont.

With spring bringing warmer weather and heavier traffic, many transportation agencies have ramped up seasonal repair efforts by launching “pothole blitzes” aimed at rapidly filling road damage ahead of the busy summer driving season.

Just last month, West Virginia Republican Gov. Patrick Morrisey [pledged](#) to have potholes across the state filled by the end of May, saying road crews had already patched more than 18,000 miles of potholes since January.

New York City also hit a [milestone](#) in April, filling 100,000 potholes in the first 100 days under Mayor Zohran Mamdani. New Yorkers called in at least 19,406 reports flagging potholes in fiscal 2026 through April, up roughly 88% from at least 10,297 reports during the same period in fiscal 2025, according to the city’s 311 [data](#).

In Baltimore, crews filled at least 32,000 potholes from late February through mid-March, and the city aims to fill another 25,000 potholes and resurface 10 lane miles by mid-July, according to Veronica McBeth, the director of the Baltimore City Department of Transportation. The agency repaired more than 134,000 potholes in 2025, she said.

“(Potholes are) one of those things that is a real pain,” McBeth said. “City services are out here trying to get the work done, and we are actively trying to grow deeper partnerships with the state to get larger pots of money to do bigger and more robust infrastructure investments.”

A growing maintenance gap

Potholes form when water seeps into cracks in pavement, freezes and expands, then melts and leaves gaps beneath the road surface. As vehicles repeatedly drive over those weakened areas the pavement breaks apart, creating potholes. The cycle is especially common in regions with frequent freeze-thaw weather swings.

“Years of that combination of traffic and climate action will cause you to have to do maintenance. Things will break down,” said Bill Buttlar, a professor of civil and environmental engineering at the University of Missouri.

Poor drainage is also a major factor, Buttlar said, as moisture and stormwater can significantly weaken pavement over time. The aging transportation systems in many parts of the country can make the problem even worse, as older roads are often more vulnerable to cracking and deterioration.

Responsibility for repairing potholes depends on who maintains the roadway. Local streets are often maintained by city or county public works departments, while state departments of transportation typically oversee highways and major roads.

Many agencies rely heavily on resident complaints submitted through 311 systems or online reporting tools to identify new potholes, alongside routine inspections and maintenance crews.

State and local governments increasingly rely on a patchwork of federal funding and local revenue sources to cover maintenance costs. [Research](#) from The Pew Charitable Trusts found that state roadways face a combined maintenance and repair shortfall of \$86.3 billion over the next decade.

“(Transportation agencies) don’t have the budget to do proper maintenance practices and stay out ahead of things, just with the increase of costs and the lack of funding that we’ve been putting into the roads as a nation over the last 30 years,” said Richard Willis of the National Asphalt Pavement Association. Willis is the industry group’s vice president for engineering, research and technology.

The lack of funding often creates a cycle of reactive maintenance, according to experts. Delaying repairs can worsen deterioration as water continues penetrating cracks and weakening pavement foundations, leading to more costly reconstruction later.

“The last thing you want to do is try to save a buck here and there, kind of kick the can down the road, and pushing the maintenance back,” Buttlar said. “It turns out, it’s less expensive to do light maintenance more often.”

Innovative tools

Some states and cities are turning to technology to stretch maintenance dollars further.

In Worcester, Massachusetts, City Councilor Satya Mitra said he wants the city to become the “city with no potholes.” Since joining the council earlier this year, Mitra said he has heard repeated concerns from residents about road safety and infrastructure conditions and is pushing for the city’s transportation officials to explore whether artificial intelligence could help detect potholes earlier.

“It is not only the damage to our vehicle that happens, but also it is a potential health risk,” Mitra told Stateline. To underscore how seriously he takes the issue, Mitra even made a T-shirt that reads, “Proud to live in Worcester, a city with no potholes,” which he said he would like to distribute to residents if the city reaches that goal.

Worcester is far from alone. Transportation agencies across the country are increasingly experimenting with AI-powered cameras, sensors and predictive software to identify road damage before it worsens. Supporters say the technology can help agencies prioritize repairs, respond faster and potentially reduce long-term maintenance costs. But for many cities already struggling with limited budgets, the systems can also come with significant upfront costs.

Last week, Chicago [announced](#) a partnership with tech company Samsara to test artificial intelligence tools designed to improve road operations. The system will use sensors and video technology to detect and log potholes.

Similar technology is also being [tested](#) in more than a handful Massachusetts communities through a pilot program using pothole detection software.



□ Worcester, Massachusetts, City Councilor Satya Mitra (Photo courtesy of Satya Mitra)

In Hawaii, the state Department of Transportation has [expanded](#) its “Eyes on the Road” initiative, which relies on volunteer drivers equipped with free dash cameras to collect roadway footage statewide.

Last year, San Jose, California, [released](#) results from an AI-powered road safety pilot project that found the technology identified potholes with 97% accuracy and roadway debris with 88% accuracy. The pilot, launched in 2023, uses cameras mounted on city vehicles to detect potholes, illegal dumping and other infrastructure problems.

In recent years, some municipalities have upgraded their 311 systems with mobile apps, photo uploads and GPS-based reporting tools aimed at making them easier and faster to use.

But some researchers warn that complaint-based systems can leave behind communities that are less likely to engage with local government reporting tools. A 2024 [study](#) published in the Policy Studies Journal found that in

Houston, lower-income neighborhoods and communities with larger Black and Hispanic populations submitted fewer 311 pothole complaints despite often having worse road conditions.

Rather than waiting for roads to deteriorate into major reconstruction projects, focusing on preventive measures such as crack sealing, resurfacing and rapid pothole patching could help more. Experts say addressing smaller problems early can extend the lifespan of roads, reduce long-term repair costs and help prevent more dangerous driving conditions.

“If we invest in maintaining what we have, that’s the most effective way to preclude the formation of potholes,” said George Conner, the deputy director for operations at the Alabama Department of Transportation. Conner also serves as the chair of the committee on maintenance with the American Association of State Highway and Transportation Officials.

“A prioritized overall preservation is probably the best starting point. But there is no single fix for potholes, especially if you want the repair to last,” Conner said.

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